

Citation Verification & Citation Mapping

A step-by-step process to verify your citations and map the literature around your paper

Objective

Every student will work with one research paper of their assigned/selected paper. By the end of this assignment, you will have completed two related but distinct processes:

- Citation Verification — checking that every claim you attribute to a source is actually supported by that source.
- Citation Mapping — using an AI-powered tool to visually explore how your paper connects to the wider literature, and to discover related work.

Note: These are two different skills. Do not use the terms interchangeably in your submission — Part A is verification, Part B is mapping.

What You Need Before Starting

- One or more research papers you are working with (PDF or link to each).
- A spreadsheet tool (Google Sheets or Excel).
- A free account on one citation-mapping tool: Connected Papers, ResearchRabbit, or LitMaps (ResearchRabbit is recommended — fully free).

Part A — Citation Verification

Goal: confirm that every claim you make about a paper is actually what that paper says, with an exact location you can point to.

Step 1: Build your tracking sheet

Create a spreadsheet with one row per paper. Use at least these columns:

Column	What to put in it
Paper ID	A short code, e.g. P01, P02 — used everywhere else instead of retyping titles.
Title / Year / DOI	Full citation details, in one consistent format.
Principal claim	The exact statement you plan to attribute to this paper in your own words.
Supporting result / evidence	The specific data, quote, or finding in the paper that backs the claim.
Evidence location	Page number or section (e.g. 'Results, p.12') where that evidence appears.
Citation-support status	Fully Supported / Partially Supported / Not Supported / Needs Verification (see Step 3).
Reported limitation	Any caveat the authors themselves note that affects how strong the claim is.

Step 2: Open the original paper and find the claim

For every row, go back to the actual paper (not an abstract, not a summary from memory) and locate the exact section that supports your claim. Write down the page or section number in 'Evidence location'.

Step 3: Classify the support level

Assign one status per paper — be honest, do not mark everything the same:

- Fully Supported — the paper directly and clearly states this claim.
- Partially Supported — the paper discusses something related, but not exactly this claim, or the evidence is thinner than the claim (small sample, no baseline, single study).
- Not Supported / Misattributed — the paper does not actually support this claim.
- Needs Verification — you are not fully sure yet and need to re-check.

Note: If every row in your sheet ends up 'Fully Supported', that is a red flag, not a good result — it usually means the check wasn't done carefully.

Step 4: Cross-link related papers

Where papers in your set relate to each other (same sub-topic, one paper's result confirms or contradicts another), note the connection in a 'Related papers' column — but only after checking, not just because the titles sound similar.

Step 5: Standardize your metadata

Use one consistent format for DOI, year, and title across every row (e.g. always the bare DOI like 10.xxxx/xxxxx, not a mix of full links and 'not available'). This matters if you later import the sheet into Zotero or Mendeley.

Step 6: Fill every gap

No blank cells. A missing evidence location or missing result means that row is not actually verified yet.

Step 7: Final consistency pass

Before submitting, check the whole sheet once more for:

- Self-citations — no paper should list itself as 'related'.
- Mutual links — if Paper A lists Paper B as related, check whether B should list A too.
- No duplicate DOIs across different papers.
- Every 'Fully Supported' status is genuinely justified, not a default value.

Part B — Citation Mapping

Goal: use an AI-powered citation tool to visually explore your paper's place in the literature and discover related work you may have missed.

Step 1: Choose a tool

Tool	Best for
ResearchRabbit (recommended, free)	Building a full collection of papers and seeing Similar / Earlier / Later work.
Connected Papers	A quick single-paper visual map (5 free maps/month).
LitMaps	A timeline view of related work.

Step 2: Start from your seed paper

Enter your paper's DOI (or upload the PDF) into the tool. Confirm it found the correct paper (check title, authors, year).

Step 3: Generate the map

Run the 'Find related articles' / 'Similar articles' search. The tool will mine that paper's references and citations to build a visual network — this works even for papers that don't directly cite each other, as long as they are topically or structurally similar.

Step 4: Build a collection (if you have multiple papers)

If you are mapping more than one paper (e.g. your full reference list), create a Collection/Library, add every paper's DOI to it, then run 'Search from Collection' → 'Similar' (and optionally 'References' and 'Citations') to get a combined network for your whole paper set.

Step 5: Review what the map shows you

- Papers already in your collection will usually be marked differently from new suggestions — note which is which.
- Read the abstracts of new suggested papers. Decide: already covered by something you have, genuinely new and relevant, or not relevant — skip.
- Add any genuinely relevant new papers to your collection / reference list.

Step 6: Export

Export your final collection (RIS file, or sync to Zotero) so it can be reused for your actual writing later.

What to Submit

Deliverable	Format
Citation-verification spreadsheet (Part A)	Google Sheet link or .xlsx, all columns completed, no blanks.
Screenshot(s) of your citation map (Part B)	PNG/JPG of the ResearchRabbit / Connected Papers / LitMaps graph.

Deliverable	Format
Short reflection (150–200 words)	What the map showed you that the spreadsheet alone didn't, and any new papers you found. (with attached citation network screenshot) in PDF.

Quick Self-Check Before Submitting

- Every claim in my sheet has an evidence location I personally verified in the original paper.
- My support-status column has more than one value — not everything is 'Fully Supported'.
- No self-citations or duplicate DOIs remain in my sheet.
- I generated an actual visual citation map using one of the listed tools (not just the spreadsheet).
- I reviewed at least a few newly suggested papers from the map and decided whether to include them.

How & Where to Submit

Do not email or hand in files directly. All submissions for this assignment must go through the Google Form linked below.

Submission Form:

<https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSfONi0xGkfCB1x-uX0TrUcLQ3havT0P9iYuc9nHnfB-fwkOsA/viewform?usp=publish-editor>